Catalogue of Key Information Manipulation Narratives in the German Information Space (2014–2026)

Executive Summary

The contemporary German-language information space remains a primary theater for cognitive warfare, characterized by the persistent convergence of Foreign Information Manipulation and Interference (FIMI) and domestic extremism. This exhaustive catalogue and threat-assessment briefing evaluates the dominant narratives that have circulated within fringe, hyperpartisan, and alternative media ecosystems from 2014 through October 2026. Following the collapse of the German coalition government and the snap federal elections of February 2025, the information environment experienced an unprecedented hybridization of foreign and domestic disinformation, heavily catalyzed by advancements in generative artificial intelligence and autonomous bot networks[1].

The core strategic objective of these overlapping operations is the systematic degradation of institutional trust, the exacerbation of societal polarization, and the demobilization of Western solidarity, particularly regarding the defense of Ukraine. Russian-aligned threat actors—most notably the Social Design Agency (responsible for the *Doppelgänger* campaign) and the Foundation to Battle Injustice (linked to the *Storm-1516* network)—have successfully laundered manufactured atrocities and forged political scandals into the German mainstream[3].

Concurrently, domestic anti-democratic milieus, including the *Neue Rechte* (New Right), the *Reichsbürger* (sovereign citizen) movement, and the post-pandemic *Querdenken* (lateral thinking) ecosystem, have opportunistically amplified these foreign inputs. These domestic groups simultaneously propagate indigenous historical-revisionist and ethnonationalist master frames to cultivate an in-group identity built on victimhood and resistance to an alleged totalitarian state[7].

This report deconstructs 25 pivotal narratives across four origin categories, providing a granular, peer-reviewed analysis of their rhetorical mechanisms, primary carriers, and strategic functions. By strictly delineating between legitimate political discourse and intentional disinformation, this assessment equips policymakers and researchers with an evidence-based taxonomy of the cognitive threats challenging the democratic resilience of the Federal Republic of Germany.

Methodology, Source Universe, and Limitations

This assessment synthesizes open-source intelligence (OSINT) investigations, governmental threat assessments, and peer-reviewed academic literature. The analysis integrates data from independent research institutes focusing on the German extremism landscape, primarily the Center für Monitoring, Analyse und Strategie (CeMAS), the Institute for Strategic Dialogue (ISD Germany), and the Friedrich-Ebert-Stiftung's (FES) longitudinal *Mitte-Studien*[1]. Academic frameworks regarding the *Querdenken* milieu rely heavily on the sociological field research

conducted by the Universität Basel[8]. Governmental and multinational data is drawn from the German Federal Office for the Protection of the Constitution (*Verfassungsschutz*), the Federal Foreign Office, and the European External Action Service (EEAS) 4th Threat Report published in March 2026[13].

The source universe spans conspiracy-theory research, far-right populism studies, and Russian information-warfare literature, treating outlets such as RT DE, *Compact*, AUF1, and NIUS strictly as subjects of analysis based on empirical monitoring, rather than assuming inherent classification[9].

A primary limitation of this research is the inherently opaque nature of algorithmic amplification on platforms such as TikTok, Telegram, and X, which obscures the precise boundary between authentic user engagement and computational amplification. Furthermore, attributing the origin of hybrid narratives requires careful parsing, as malign actors frequently utilize "narrative laundering" to obscure their involvement. To address this, the report employs a rigid evidence scale for attribution, ensuring that speculative links are not presented as established facts.

Taxonomy Explained

The analytical taxonomy classifies each identified narrative along five interrelated axes:

1. **Origin:** Narratives are categorized as *Russian-originated* (directly traced to Russian state or proxy actors), *German-originated* (arising from domestic historical or political traditions), *Transnational/Imported* (originating externally, such as US alt-right concepts, but localized for Germany), or *Hybrid/Contested* (where origin is mixed, or a domestic issue is hijacked by foreign actors).
2. **Thematic Cluster:** Groupings include (a) Delegitimization of democracy and state institutions; (b) Migration, identity, and demographic narratives; (c) Ukraine war and foreign policy; (d) Energy, climate, and economy; (e) Health, biopolitics, and science; (f) History and memory politics; (g) Gender and "traditional values"; and (h) Antisemitic and elite-conspiracy meta-narratives.
3. **Ecosystem of Carriers:** The primary networks transmitting the narrative, including the far-right/AfD-adjacent sphere, the *Neue Rechte*, the *Querdenken* milieu, *Reichsbürger* sovereignists, left-nationalist/peace movements, and foreign state-aligned media.
4. **Type:** Clarification of the narrative's epistemological status, ranging from *Disinformation* (verifiably false with intent to deceive), *Misinformation* (false without intent), *Malinformation* (factual but intentionally weaponized out of context), *Propaganda*, *Conspiracy Narrative*, or an *Ideological Master Frame*.
5. **Evidence Strength for Attribution:**
   - **Level A:** Uncontested attribution documented by official government, EU sources, or multiple independent technical investigations.
   - **Level B:** High probability supported by peer-reviewed literature or reputable think-tank analysis using transparent methods.
   - **Level C:** Probable, based on investigative journalism with verifiable documents/data.
   - **Level D:** Plausible but contested or reliant on a single source.
   - **Level E:** Highly speculative; lacking empirical grounding.

Master Table of Narratives

ID	Narrative Name (EN / Original DE)	Origin Class	Thematic Cluster	Type	Main Carriers	Evidence Level	Key Sources
01	Ukraine Denazification / *Entnazifizierung*	Russian	(c) Ukraine	Disinfo / Propaganda	RT DE, Storm-1516, Left-nationalists	Level A	[9]
02	NATO Provocation / *NATO-Osterweiterung*	Russian	(c) Ukraine	Propaganda / Frame	AfD, Peace Movement, RT DE	Level A	[9]
03	Sanctions Boomerang / *Sanktions-Bumerang*	Russian	(c), (d) Economy	Malinfo / Propaganda	AfD, Compact, Doppelgänger	Level A	[13]
04	Bucha Denial / *Butscha-Lüge*	Russian	(c) Ukraine	Disinformation	Alt-Media, Telegram	Level A	[20]
05	Zelensky's Hitler House / *Hitler-H*	Russian	(c), (h) Elite	Disinformation	Storm-1516, X, TikTok	Level A	[6]

	aus						
06	Digital Concentration Camp / *Digitales KZ*	Russian	(a) State	Disinformation	Storm-1516, Querdenken	Level B	[21]
07	Faked Media Clones / *Doppelgänger Fakes*	Russian	(a) Media	Disinformation	Social Design Agency, Bots	Level A	[1]
08	Sovereign State Denial / *BRD GmbH*	German	(a) State	Conspiracy Narrative	Reichsbürger, Selbstverwalter	Level A	[7]
09	Lying Press / *Lügenpresse*	German	(a) Media	Ideological Frame	Pegida, AfD, AUF1, NIUS	Level B	[17]
10	Great Replacement / *Großer Austausch*	German (Local)	(b) Migration	Conspiracy Narrative	Identitarian Movement, AfD	Level B	[11]
11	Coalition Dictatorship / *Ampel-*	German	(a) State	Malinformation	Compact, Querdenken	Level B	[8]

	Diktatur						
12	Climate Expropriation / *Heizungsgesetz*	German	(d) Climate	Malinfo / Propaganda	Tichys Einblick, NIUS, AfD	Level C	[18]
13	Guilt Cult / *Schuldkult*	German	(f) History	Ideological Frame	Far-right, Neue Rechte	Level B	[26]
14	Cartel Parties / *Altparteienkartell*	German	(a) State	Ideological Frame	AfD, Compact, AUF1	Level B	[11]
15	AfD Ban as Democracy Demise	German	(a) State	Propaganda	AfD, Right-wing influencers	Level B	[1]
16	The Great Reset / *Great Reset*	Transnat.	(h) Elite	Conspiracy Narrative	Querdenken, AUF1	Level B	[1]
17	Gender Madness / *Genderwahn*	Transnat.	(g) Gender	Ideological Frame	Far-right, Alt-media	Level B	[28]
18	Globalists / *Ostküst*	Transnat.	(h) Elite	Conspiracy Narrativ	Reichsbürger, Querde	Level B	[7]

	e / Soros			e	nken		
19	Climate Dictatorship / *Klimadiktatur*	Transnat.	(d) Climate	Conspiracy Narrative	AfD, Fossil-fuel lobbies	Level B	[1]
20	Migrant Atrocity Fakes / *Fall Lisa*	Hybrid	(b) Migration	Disinformation	Doppelgänger, AfD, Telegram	Level A	[1]
21	2025 Election Fraud / *Wahlbetrug*	Hybrid	(a) State	Disinformation	Storm-1516, AfD influencers	Level A	[1]
22	Peace Movement / *Friedensbewegung*	Hybrid	(c) Ukraine	Malinfo / Propaganda	Left-nationalists, Far-right	Level C	[9]
23	US Vassal State / *US-Kolonie*	Hybrid	(c) Geopol.	Conspiracy Narrative	Reichsbürger, RT DE	Level B	[3]
24	Nord Stream US Blame	Hybrid	(c) Geopol.	Propaganda / Speculative	Left-nationalists, AfD, RT	Level C	[19]
25	Intentio	Hybrid	(d)	Conspir	Compa	Level B	[17]

	nal Deindustrialization		Economy	acy Narrative	ct, AfD, Alt-media		

Section A: Russian-Originated Narratives

The operational doctrine of Russian FIMI relies on the "firehose of falsehood" model, an evolution of Cold War Soviet active measures designed not necessarily to persuade audiences of a single truth, but to overwhelm the cognitive environment and degrade the concept of verifiable reality[31]. In the contemporary German space, state-aligned proxies such as the *Storm-1516* network and the *Doppelgänger* infrastructure have increasingly utilized generative artificial intelligence to fabricate scandals, clone legitimate media, and launder narratives through proxy influencers, specifically targeting the 2024–2026 electoral cycles[3].

01. Ukraine Denazification (*Entnazifizierung der Ukraine*)

The narrative commonly identified as "Ukraine Denazification" posits that the Ukrainian government and its military are structurally controlled by neo-Nazi elements, framing the Russian Federation's invasion as a legitimate continuation of historical anti-fascist efforts. Classified within the Ukraine war thematic cluster, this disinformation frame originated directly from the Kremlin's strategic communications apparatus in the lead-up to the February 2022 invasion[9]. In the German-language space, the narrative was seeded by Russian state media such as RT DE and Sputnik, and subsequently amplified by pro-Russian influencers and left-nationalist forums. The strategic purpose is to provide moral justification for the invasion, delegitimize Western military aid, and fracture European consensus by exploiting Germany's acute historical sensitivity to National Socialism. Rhetorically, it relies on a "kernel-of-truth" mechanism, taking the historical existence of far-right battalions and inflating it into a structural generalization of the entire Ukrainian state. Factually, the core claim is false; while right-wing extremism exists in Ukraine, the government is a pluralistic, democratically elected administration. Russian involvement is graded at Level A, given the explicit documentation by EU threat reports and CeMAS, which notes that between 5-10% of the German domestic audience exhibits belief in this framing[9].

02. NATO Provocation (*NATO-Osterweiterung als Provokation*)

This narrative asserts that NATO’s eastward expansion intentionally threatened Russian security, effectively forcing Moscow into a defensive war and making the West the true aggressor in the Ukraine conflict. Originating as a historical Soviet grievance, it was systematically weaponized post-2014 by Russian state media[9]. In Germany, typical carriers include AfD parliamentarians, left-nationalist peace alliances, alternative outlets like *Nachdenkseiten*, and the remnants of the RT DE ecosystem. The strategic function is to shift moral and diplomatic blame from Moscow to Washington and Brussels, thereby demobilizing German military and financial support for Kyiv. Psychologically, it leverages whataboutism and victimhood framing. The factual status is highly distorted; while NATO did expand, it occurred through the voluntary accession of sovereign democratic states seeking security guarantees,

not through military aggression against Russian territory. Attribution to Russian active measures is Level A, with CeMAS data indicating up to 19% domestic agreement in Germany, illustrating its profound reach across political divides[9].

03. Sanctions Boomerang (*Sanktions-Bumerang*)

The "Sanctions Boomerang" narrative claims that Western economic sanctions against Russia are completely destroying the German economy and industrial base, while the Russian economy remains robust and unaffected. Emerging immediately after the implementation of sanctions in February 2022, this malinformation campaign was heavily pushed by Russian diplomatic channels and the *Doppelgänger* typo-squatting network[13]. Domestically, it is championed by AfD networks and formerly by *Compact* magazine prior to its 2024 ban[17]. The strategic purpose is to foster acute domestic economic panic to break the European sanctions consensus. It rhetorically exploits legitimate economic anxieties regarding inflation, energy prices, and deindustrialization, using a scapegoating mechanism. Factually, the narrative is a distortion; while sanctions have undeniably impacted European energy costs, macroeconomic data demonstrates severe long-term structural damage to the Russian economy. Attribution to Russian influence operations is Level A, with detailed documentation of *Doppelgänger* bot networks artificially amplifying the claim on social media[13].

04. Bucha Denial (*Butscha-Lüge*)

This disinformation narrative explicitly denies Russian war crimes, claiming that the atrocities in Bucha were staged by Ukrainian intelligence or Western actors using crisis actors and fake corpses. It originated from the Russian Ministry of Defense in April 2022 and was blasted across Telegram channels globally[20]. In Germany, it found a receptive audience within conspiracy-ideological networks, particularly the *Querdenken* milieu. The strategic purpose is atrocity denial, intended to maintain moral ambiguity and disrupt international momentum for war-crimes tribunals. It operates on the "firehose of falsehood" psychological mechanism, simultaneously introducing multiple contradictory alternative theories (e.g., the bodies were actors, or the bodies were killed by Ukrainian artillery) to paralyze objective assessment. Factually, the claim is entirely false, having been exhaustively debunked by the UN, independent forensic journalists, and satellite imagery. Attribution is Level A[20].

05. Zelensky's Hitler House (*Hitler-Haus*)

This highly specific disinformation narrative falsely claims that Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky used misappropriated Western financial aid to purchase a house formerly owned by Adolf Hitler. Emerging in February 2025 during the German snap election cycle, it was generated by the *Storm-1516* operation—a network linked to the Russian Foundation to Battle Injustice[6]. The narrative was introduced via fake news sites and amplified by Russian-aligned influencers on X and TikTok, eventually being shared by some AfD politicians[21]. The strategic purpose is dual-fold: to delegitimize Zelensky to halt financial aid, and to subconsciously reinforce the overarching "Ukraine equals Nazi" master frame. The mechanism relies on sophisticated digital forgery, including faked property deeds and computational amplification by bot networks. Factually, it is entirely fabricated. Evidence of Russian origin is Level A, confirmed by multiple OSINT investigations into the *Storm-1516* architecture[6].

06. Digital Concentration Camp (*Digitales KZ*)

This narrative asserts that the German government is secretly utilizing digital identification, central bank digital currencies, and health data to construct a totalitarian "digital concentration camp." While tapping into transnational anxieties regarding the "Great Reset," this specific highly aggressive iteration was traced to a *Storm-1516* operation in December 2024[21]. It is carried primarily by *Querdenken* Telegram channels and alternative media proxies. The strategic function is to induce profound anti-government panic, delegitimize state authority, and potentially incite kinetic resistance. The psychological mechanism relies on historical relativization (holocaust inversion) combined with intense technological paranoia. Factually, it is a false fabrication designed to mirror and inflame post-COVID domestic surveillance fears. Attribution to Russian amplification is Level B, as the specific December 2024 push was documented by CeMAS tracking of *Storm-1516* assets[21].

07. Faked Media Clones (*Doppelgänger Meta-Narrative*)

Rather than a single claim, this is a meta-narrative asserting that mainstream legacy outlets (such as SPIEGEL, Süddeutsche Zeitung, and Welt) are secretly publishing articles that confirm Russian propaganda points regarding Ukraine and the economy. The origin is the Social Design Agency (SDA), exposed initially in August 2022, which continued iterative campaigns well into the 2025 election cycle[1]. The carriers are typo-squatting domains (e.g., spiegel[.]bz) heavily promoted via paid Facebook advertisements and X botnets[3]. The strategic purpose is to bypass the inherent source-skepticism of German audiences by hijacking the established credibility and visual branding of legacy media. The mechanism is visual deception and institutional mimicry. Factually, the assertion that mainstream media published these articles is false; the websites are sophisticated, hostile clones. Attribution is Level A, documented extensively by the German Federal Foreign Office and EEAS threat reports[13].

Section B: German-Originated (Domestic) Narratives

Domestic narratives are deeply entrenched in German historical revisionism, anti-establishment populism, and the epistemological rebellion characteristic of the *Querdenken* protests[8]. Rather than being foreign imports, these narratives function as ideological master frames that create a rigid in-group identity predicated on victimization by an allegedly totalitarian, treacherous state apparatus. Russian actors frequently boost these narratives opportunistically, but the ideation and primary momentum remain domestic.

08. Sovereign State Denial (*BRD GmbH*)

This foundational conspiracy narrative asserts that the Federal Republic of Germany is not a sovereign, legitimate state, but rather a commercial corporation (the *BRD GmbH*) governed by Allied occupation laws, meaning the borders of the 1871 German Empire or the 1919 Weimar Republic remain legally valid. Originating in 1980s right-wing extremism, it expanded massively in the 2010s through the *Reichsbürger* and *Selbstverwalter* (sovereign citizen) movements[7]. Carriers include groups like the Patriotic Union and diverse esoteric Telegram channels. The strategic purpose is to provide a pseudo-legal justification for mass non-compliance, tax evasion, institutional defiance, and armed insurrection, as evidenced by the thwarted 2022 coup

plot[7]. The psychological mechanism relies on selective, bad-faith legal interpretation, often misusing a 1973 Constitutional Court ruling regarding the German Reich[7]. Factually, the claim is entirely false; Germany is a fully sovereign, internationally recognized democratic republic. Attribution is Level A (Domestic), with the *Verfassungsschutz* continuously tracking the movement's growth[14].

09. Lying Press (*Lügenpresse / Systemmedien*)

The "Lying Press" narrative posits that all mainstream media organizations are state-directed propaganda organs conspiring to suppress the truth and manipulate the public. The term has deep historical roots in 19th-century anti-Catholic and later National Socialist rhetoric, but was revived in the contemporary era by the PEGIDA movement in 2014[11]. Today, it is a ubiquitous ideological frame utilized by the AfD, banned outlets like *Compact*, and digital alternative media such as AUF1 and NIUS[17]. Its strategic purpose is to inoculate audiences against factual reporting and institutional fact-checking, establishing alternative, hyperpartisan media as the sole legitimate arbiters of truth. Psychologically, it enforces in-group epistemic closure. Factually, the claim of a centrally coordinated "lying press" conspiracy is false, though media criticism regarding editorial bias or groupthink remains a legitimate democratic exercise. Attribution as a domestic master frame is Level B, extensively tracked by the FES *Mitte-Studien*[11].

10. Great Replacement (*Großer Austausch / Remigration*)

This conspiracy narrative claims that global or national elites are intentionally engineering the demographic replacement of white European populations with non-European migrants, positing that the only solution is "Remigration" (forced mass deportation). While the specific phrasing originated in France with Renaud Camus in 2011, it was heavily localized and adopted as a central master frame by the German and Austrian Identitarian Movements and the *Neue Rechte*[11]. It is carried extensively by the *Institut für Staatspolitik* and radical factions within the AfD. The strategic purpose is to foster existential demographic panic, framing migration not as a policy challenge but as an apocalyptic threat requiring radical, anti-constitutional ethnonationalist countermeasures. The psychological mechanism relies on scapegoating and the inflation of existential threat. Factually, while demographic shifts and migration challenges are real, the assertion of a coordinated elite conspiracy to eradicate the white race is false. Attribution as a localized domestic narrative is Level B[11].

11. Coalition Dictatorship (*Ampel-Diktatur / Merkel-Diktatur*)

This malinformation narrative asserts that democratic governments in Germany—whether the previous Merkel administration or the subsequent SPD/Green/FDP coalition—operate as de facto dictatorships that actively suppress freedom of opinion and civil liberties. Morphing from the 2015 "Merkel-Diktatur" framing to the 2020 "Corona-Diktatur" and finally the "Ampel-Diktatur," it is heavily promoted by the *Querdenken* milieu, the AfD, and alternative media[8]. The strategic purpose is to delegitimize democratic elections, normalize aggressive anti-government rhetoric, and justify radical, sometimes violent, resistance. The psychological mechanism is concept creep and semantic inversion, deliberately labeling pluralistic democratic governance as totalitarianism. Factually, the narrative is false; Germany remains a functioning

constitutional democracy with robust judicial review, though dissatisfaction with specific policies is widespread and legitimate. Attribution is Level B, supported by sociological analyses of the protest milieus[8].

12. Climate Expropriation (*Heizungsgesetz will enteignen*)

Emerging predominantly during the 2023–2024 debates over the Building Energy Act (*Gebäudeenergiegesetz*), this narrative claims that Green party energy policies are deliberate, malicious attempts to bankrupt and expropriate the German middle class under the guise of climate protection[1]. It was propelled by outlets like Tichys Einblick, NIUS, the AfD, and heavily amplified in sensationalized forms by mainstream tabloid press. The strategic purpose is to weaponize economic anxiety to block climate transition policies and politically destroy the Green party. The rhetorical mechanism utilizes the slippery slope fallacy and extreme hyperbole. Factually, the narrative is distorted; the proposed legislation did contain costly mandates that sparked highly legitimate economic and political debate, but framing it as a "communist expropriation plot" crosses into malinformation and propaganda. Attribution is Level C, documented by ISD Germany's tracking of climate disinformation[25].

13. Guilt Cult (*Schuldkult*)

The "Guilt Cult" narrative argues that Germany's post-war culture of remembrance regarding the Holocaust is an artificially imposed psychological weapon designed to keep the nation spiritually subjugated and prevent the development of a healthy national identity. A long-standing staple of German neo-Nazism, it was mainstreamed into parliamentary discourse by AfD politicians (e.g., referring to the Holocaust memorial as a "memorial of shame"). It is carried by far-right influencers and *Neue Rechte* publications. The strategic purpose is historical revisionism aimed at rehabilitating aggressive nationalism and removing the moral guardrails of post-war German democracy. The psychological mechanism relies on national narcissism and historical inversion. Factually, the claim is an ideological falsehood; remembrance culture is an internally developed, foundational aspect of modern German democratic identity. Attribution is Level B, continuously tracked by the Leipzig Authoritarianism Studies[26].

14. Cartel Parties (*Altparteienkartell*)

This ideological frame posits that all established democratic parties (CDU, SPD, Greens, FDP) constitute an indistinguishable, corrupt "cartel" acting explicitly against the interests of the German people. Popularized by the AfD since its inception, it is a classic right-wing populist trope carried across the alternative media spectrum[11]. The strategic purpose is to position the AfD as the sole authentic democratic alternative to a supposedly monolithic establishment. The psychological mechanism relies on false equivalence and the populist dichotomy of the "pure people" versus the "corrupt elite." Factually, the narrative is distorted; while grand coalitions and centrist compromises can blur policy distinctions, the established parties possess distinct platforms, ideological histories, and voter bases. Attribution is Level B[11].

15. AfD Ban as Democracy Demise (*AfD-Verbot ist Demokratie-Abbau*)

Surging in late 2024 and early 2025 following widespread anti-extremism protests and debates over a constitutional ban of the AfD, this propaganda narrative claims that the "cartel parties" are attempting to ban the AfD merely to eliminate political competition, thereby abolishing

democracy itself[1]. Promoted heavily by the AfD and right-wing X/Twitter ecosystems, its strategic purpose is victimhood framing—recasting a protective mechanism of Germany's militant democracy (*streitbare Demokratie*) as evidence of elite totalitarianism. The psychological mechanism is the reversal of perpetrator and victim. Factually, the narrative is distorted; Article 21 of the Basic Law allows for the banning of anti-constitutional parties specifically to *protect* the democratic order. However, the political wisdom and democratic implications of utilizing this mechanism remain a subject of highly legitimate debate. Attribution is Level B[1].

Section C: Transnational / Imported Narratives

Transnational narratives generally originate within the US alt-right or global conspiracist milieus and undergo heavy localization for the German context. These meta-narratives are highly effective at unifying disparate fringe groups—ranging from esoteric anti-vaxxers to right-wing extremists—under a shared cosmology of global elite oppression[8].

16. The Great Reset

This conspiracy narrative asserts that the World Economic Forum (WEF) and figures like Klaus Schwab orchestrated or utilized the COVID-19 pandemic to institute a totalitarian global government, stripping citizens of property and freedom. Evolving from a genuine WEF economic initiative title into a global conspiracy theory in 2020, it is heavily promoted in Germany by the *Querdenken* milieu, AUF1, and alternative medicine networks[1]. The strategic purpose is to unify anti-vaccine, anti-climate, and anti-government movements against a singular, shadowy global enemy. The psychological mechanism relies on apophenia (finding malicious connections in random data) and elite panic. Factually, it is false; the WEF is an influential lobbying forum for global capitalism, but it lacks both the executive power and the coordinated intent to enact a global dictatorship. Attribution is Level B[8].

17. Gender Madness (*Genderwahn / Woke Mind Virus*)

The "Gender Madness" frame claims that "woke" ideology, LGBTQ+ rights, and gender studies are deliberate tools used by elites to destroy the traditional nuclear family, feminize men, and indoctrinate children (often termed *Frühsexualisierung*). Imported primarily from the US culture wars, it has successfully merged with Russian "traditional values" state propaganda and domestic Christian-conservative anxieties[28]. Carriers include *Junge Freiheit*, NIUS, the AfD, and Russian state media. The strategic purpose is to mobilize conservative voters through intense moral panic and to conceptually align Western far-right actors with Russian social policies. The psychological mechanism relies on disgust elicitation and moral panic. Factually, the narrative is distorted; debates over gender pedagogy and inclusive language (*Gendern*) are legitimate, but claims of a coordinated elite plot to "destroy society" via LGBTQ+ rights constitute an ideological master frame. Attribution is Level B, explored deeply in the Leipzig Authoritarianism Study on Antifeminism[28].

18. Globalists (*Die Ostküste / Soros*)

This structurally antisemitic conspiracy narrative claims that a shadowy cabal of "globalists"—often coded language referring to Jewish elites, George Soros, or the Rothschild

family—secretly controls world finance, media, and politics. It represents a modern manifestation of the *Protocols of the Elders of Zion*, continuously adapted via transnational networks like QAnon[7]. In Germany, it is prevalent among *Reichsbürger*, *Querdenken*, and far-right Telegram channels. The strategic purpose is to provide a simplistic, personified scapegoat for complex macroeconomic and geopolitical crises. The psychological mechanism utilizes dog-whistling, allowing adherents to express antisemitic tropes without explicitly mentioning Jews. Factually, the claim of a unified globalist cabal controlling world events is entirely false. Attribution is Level B[9].

19. Climate Dictatorship / Climate Hoax (*Klimawahn / Klimadiktatur*)

This narrative posits that anthropogenic climate change is a hoax, or vastly exaggerated, by globalists in order to enforce a "climate dictatorship" designed to control individual behavior (e.g., through 15-minute cities or meat bans). Originating in US fossil fuel lobbying, it morphed into a populist conspiracy theory and escalated heavily in Germany[1]. It is carried by the AfD, AUF1, and libertarian fringe outlets. The strategic purpose is to obstruct environmental legislation and fuel anti-establishment sentiment by portraying ecological policy as tyranny. The psychological mechanism relies on denialism and reactance (resistance to perceived loss of personal freedom). Factually, the narrative is false; climate change is a verified scientific consensus, and concepts like "15-minute cities" are benign urban planning frameworks, not lockdown measures. Attribution is Level B, documented by the NOTORIOUS project on climate disinformation[25].

Section D: Hybrid / Laundered Narratives

Hybrid narratives represent the most complex threat vector, featuring contested or mixed origins. They frequently begin as genuine domestic incidents or anxieties, which are subsequently hijacked, fabricated into atrocities, and amplified by foreign FIMI networks to maximize societal trauma and polarization[37].

20. Migrant Atrocity Fakes (*Fall Lisa* to 2025 Euskirchen Fakes)

This disinformation archetype claims that migrants or refugees are committing brutal, unprovoked crimes against local populations, and that the state and media are actively covering it up. The prototype was the 2016 "Lisa Case," where Russian state media amplified a false rape claim in Berlin to incite mass protests[29]. This tactic was replicated in 2022 with a fake story about Ukrainian refugees in Euskirchen, and again in early 2025 by *Storm-1516*, which fabricated a story about an Islamist murder in Germany[1]. Carriers include *Doppelgänger* clones, Russian embassies, and local AfD chapters. The strategic purpose is to incite racial violence and demonstrate absolute state failure. The mechanism is atrocity propaganda and emotional hijacking. Factually, while migrant crime is a real and legitimate political issue, these specific, highly viral instances were verified fabrications. Attribution is Level A[1].

21. 2025 Election Fraud (*Wahlbetrug*)

Targeting the February 2025 snap elections, this narrative claimed the election was rigged against the AfD through manipulated postal votes and systemic fraud, pushing for a "fake re-run." The playbook was hybridized from US "Stop the Steal" tactics and injected with Russian

Storm-1516 AI-generated videos depicting ballot stuffing in Germany[1]. It spread rapidly across X, TikTok, and via AfD influencers. The strategic purpose was to destroy faith in the democratic process and incite post-election unrest. Psychologically, it relied on pre-bunking democratic outcomes (claiming fraud before the vote) and the algorithmic amplification of deepfakes[39]. Factually, the narrative was false; the German electoral system is decentralized and highly secure, and the viral videos were proven AI fabrications. Attribution is Level A[1].

22. Peace Movement (*Friedensbewegung / Diplomatie statt Waffen*)

This narrative frames Germany's delivery of defensive weapons to Ukraine as aggressive warmongering, arguing that Germany must cease all military aid to achieve "peace." It is a hybridization of traditional German left-wing pacifism (rooted in the Cold War) co-opted by Russian strategic narratives and right-wing populism (evidenced by the convergence of the BSW and AfD)[9]. Carriers include the Bündnis Sahra Wagenknecht (BSW), the AfD, *Overton Magazin*, and RT DE. The strategic purpose is to cut off military aid to Ukraine, which would functionally guarantee a Russian military victory. The psychological mechanism involves semantic manipulation, redefining capitulation and subjugation as "peace." Factually, the narrative is highly distorted; the desire for peace is a legitimate political stance, but the narrative intentionally omits that a cessation of Western arms deliveries without a Russian withdrawal leads to the occupation of Ukraine. Attribution to hybrid influence is Level C[9].

23. US Vassal State (*Deutschland als US-Kolonie*)

This conspiracy narrative claims that Germany is not a sovereign actor but a puppet state of the United States, forced into policies (such as Ukraine aid and energy embargoes) that are diametrically opposed to its own economic interests. It merges Cold War left-wing anti-imperialism with *Reichsbürger* ideology, heavily amplified by Russian multipolar propaganda[3]. Carriers include *Compact*, *Reichsbürger* networks, RT DE, and *Nachdenkseiten*. The strategic purpose is to fracture the transatlantic alliance and justify a geopolitical pivot toward Russia. The psychological mechanism relies on a national humiliation frame. Factually, the claim is false; Germany is a sovereign state making independent, though deeply integrated, geopolitical choices within the NATO framework. Attribution is Level B[3].

24. Nord Stream Sabotage (US Blame Frame)

Following the September 2022 explosions, this narrative asserts that the United States (often citing Seymour Hersh's contested blog post) blew up the Nord Stream pipelines specifically to force Germany into energy dependence on expensive US liquified natural gas (LNG). It was amplified massively by Russian state media and domestic anti-Western actors[19]. Carriers include the AfD, left-nationalist media, and Russian diplomatic accounts. The strategic purpose is to drive a wedge between Berlin and Washington, framing the US as a state sponsor of terrorism against its own allies. The psychological mechanism exploits investigative vacuums and "Cui bono?" (Who benefits?) reductionism. Factually, the narrative remains speculative and contested; official German and international investigations have pointed heavily toward a Ukrainian sabotage group, while claims of direct US involvement lack verified evidentiary backing and function primarily as propaganda. Attribution is Level C[20].

25. Intentional Deindustrialization (*Deindustrialisierung als Absicht*)

This narrative argues that the current government and global elites are *intentionally* destroying Germany's industrial base to force compliance with a green agenda or to purposefully weaken the nation. It is a hybridization of legitimate economic anxiety regarding post-2022 energy prices with the transnational "Great Reset" narrative[17]. Carriers include *Compact*, AUF1, and AfD economic spokespersons. The strategic purpose is to translate macroeconomic shocks (caused by the Ukraine war and inflation) into a narrative of intentional domestic treason. The psychological mechanism relies on intentionality bias—the cognitive tendency to believe that systemic, negative outcomes are the result of deliberate, malicious planning rather than complex systemic factors. Factually, the narrative is false; Germany faces genuine, severe structural economic challenges, but there is no intentional elite conspiracy to destroy the nation's industry. Attribution is Level B[18].

Cross-Analysis: Mechanisms, Convergence, and Impact

Russian-Seeded vs. Domestically Amplified Narratives

A critical distinction in threat assessment is determining the genesis of a narrative. Operations like *Storm-1516* or the 2016 *Fall Lisa* are distinctly Russian-seeded[21]. They involve the outright fabrication of events (e.g., fake rapes, fake property purchases by Zelensky) engineered by foreign intelligence proxies and pushed into the German space to test domestic vulnerabilities. Conversely, narratives like the *Lügenpresse* or the *Ampel-Diktatur* are domestic master frames. They arise organically from Germany's own political friction and historical baggage. Russian FIMI actors do not need to invent these domestic narratives; they merely operate as opportunistic amplifiers, utilizing bot networks to artificially boost their prevalence and deepen existing societal fault lines[13].

The "Horseshoe" Convergence and Issue Overlap

The 2014–2026 period is defined by the dissolution of traditional left-right political dichotomies, better conceptualized through the "issue overlap" framework rather than a strict horseshoe theory. The *Querdenken* anti-lockdown protests served as the critical epistemological bridge. As demonstrated by the Universität Basel sociological studies, the *Querdenken* milieu was largely middle-class, highly educated, and self-identified as anti-authoritarian, yet it exhibited profound susceptibilities to antisemitic tropes and systemic democratic alienation[8]. By 2022, this infrastructure seamlessly pivoted to pro-Russian, anti-NATO geopolitics[20]. Consequently, left-nationalist groups (such as the BSW) and far-right ethnonationalists (AfD) converged on shared master narratives: anti-Americanism, anti-elitism, and a demand for a return to cheap Russian energy[9].

Narrative Life Cycles and Laundering

Narratives rarely originate in the mainstream; they undergo a distinct laundering process designed to obscure their origins:

1. **Seeding:** Russian actors generate a fabricated incident using AI or crisis actors, hosting the content on obscure platforms or fake news sites[1].
2. **Amplification:** Bot networks and proxy influencers (e.g., Foundation to Battle Injustice)

push the content to permissive platforms like Telegram and X[6].

3. **Domestic Adoption:** Hyperpartisan domestic media (e.g., NIUS, AUF1) or populist politicians pick up the claim, stripping it of its Russian origins to present it as domestic news[18].
4. **Mainstreaming:** The narrative generates sufficient algorithmic outrage that legacy media is forced to cover it (even in the form of a debunk), inadvertently amplifying the core claim to the broader public[1].

Narrative Adaptation Over Time (2014–2026)

The thematic focus of information manipulation adapts rapidly to geopolitical crises. Pre-2020, narratives focused heavily on migration and institutional distrust (e.g., PEGIDA and the Lisa Case). From 2020 to 2022, the landscape was dominated by COVID-19 biopolitics and the Great Reset, with Telegram emerging as the central mobilization engine[8]. Post-2022, the ecosystem executed a hard pivot to the Ukraine war, utilizing *Doppelgänger* operations to clone German media[3]. By the 2024–2026 electoral cycles, the threat evolved into the weaponization of generative AI. *Storm-1516* targeted the snap elections by combining deepfakes with domestic fraud narratives (*Wahlbetrug*), signaling a decisive shift from text-based propaganda to high-fidelity audio-visual manipulation[1].

Counter-Evidence and Scholarly Disagreements

It is vital to acknowledge critiques within the academic community regarding the application of the "disinformation" label. Some scholars and sociologists warn that governments and legacy media occasionally overuse the term to delegitimize valid populist grievances or policy disagreements—such as debates over the economic feasibility of the *Heizungsgesetz* or the diplomatic strategy in Ukraine[19]. Furthermore, there is a recognized danger of overattributing domestic political friction to "Russian bots," which can inadvertently absolve domestic political actors of their responsibility for driving polarization. However, while these critiques are valid for border-case political discourse, the operations detailed in this report (e.g., *Doppelgänger* typo-squatting, AI-generated ballot stuffing) cross the threshold from contested political discourse into verifiable, malicious information manipulation[3].

Empirical Reach and Audience Belief

Disinformation is not an edge-case phenomenon confined to digital fringes; survey data demonstrates alarming penetration into the German mainstream. FES *Mitte-Studien* (2024/2025) reveal that 24% of the population doubts the basic functionality of the democracy, and up to 20% hold ambivalent or open attitudes toward right-wing extremist narratives[11]. Furthermore, CeMAS polling indicates that approximately 19% of Germans agree that NATO provoked the Ukraine war, and up to 18% believe Vladimir Putin is fighting a global elite[9]. This empirical data suggests that cognitive warfare has successfully established a sustained counter-reality for roughly one-fifth of the German electorate.

Timeline of Key Operations, Events, and Narrative Surges

- **January 2016:** *The Lisa Case.* Russian state media fabricates the rape of a

Russian-German girl by migrants in Berlin, sparking mass protests. This event serves as the prototype for modern hybrid FIMI operations in Germany[29].

- **August 2020:** *Querdenken Protests.* Mass mobilization in Berlin culminates in sovereignists attempting to storm the Reichstag steps. The milieu solidifies as a primary vector for transnational conspiracy theories[8].
- **February 2022:** *Invasion of Ukraine.* The alternative media ecosystem executes an immediate, unified pivot toward anti-NATO, pro-Russian, and anti-sanctions narratives[9].
- **August 2022:** *Doppelgänger Exposed.* European intelligence uncovers a massive SDA-run typo-squatting campaign cloning German media to launder anti-Ukraine narratives[1].
- **December 2022:** *Reichsbürger Raids.* Police dismantle the "Patriotic Union" coup plot, highlighting the kinetic, violent danger of the *BRD GmbH* and QAnon narratives[7].
- **July 2024:** *Compact Magazine Banned.* The German Interior Ministry bans the central organ of the *Neue Rechte* for inciting hatred and attacking the constitutional democratic order[17].
- **February 2025:** *Snap Federal Elections.* Extensive digital interference by *Storm-1516*; AI-generated fake scandals targeting politicians and fabricated ballot-stuffing videos circulate widely to undermine the election's legitimacy[1].
- **March 2026:** *EEAS 4th Threat Report.* The EU confirms that AI-generated FIMI has moved from experimental to routine, with Germany remaining a primary, persistent target for Russian cognitive warfare[15].

Open Questions, Contested Points, and Research Gaps

Despite extensive institutional tracking and OSINT documentation, several critical gaps remain in the academic and intelligence understanding of the German information space:

1. **Algorithmic Complicity vs. Actor Intent:** A major unresolved debate is the extent to which localized narrative surges are driven by organic, authentic user behavior versus the structural, engagement-driven design of recommendation algorithms on platforms like TikTok and X. The exact "computational amplification" quotient utilized by state actors remains opaque to researchers without backend platform access[1].
2. **Long-term Efficacy of Debunking:** Research remains contested on whether pre-bunking and institutional fact-checking successfully mitigate the effects of high-fidelity AI deepfakes. Cognitive psychologists debate whether the mere exposure to a fake video (e.g., the *Storm-1516* election fraud fakes) creates a lingering "illusory truth effect" that persists in the voter's subconscious even after a thorough, factual debunking[20].
3. **The "Laundering" Black Box:** While entities like the Foundation to Battle Injustice (R-FBI) are known proxies, the exact financial, communicative, and logistical links between Russian military intelligence (GRU/FSB) and domestic alternative media operators in Germany lack total forensic transparency. Uncovering the exact mechanisms of coordination between foreign state actors and domestic hyperpartisan influencers

remains the primary objective for future counter-FIMI intelligence efforts[5].

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